

Critical Items Diagram

Surface the assumptions most critical and most uncertain

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

A Critical Items Diagram plots the assumptions behind a concept on two axes — how **critical** each is to success and how **uncertain** it is — so the team can prioritise testing the assumptions that are both essential and unknown. It directs scarce validation effort where risk is highest.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

Part of the HPI/Stanford-derived design toolkit; related to Bland and Osterwalder's assumptions-mapping practice.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Teams often test what is easy rather than what matters. Ranking assumptions by criticality and uncertainty focuses experimentation on make-or-break unknowns.

HOW IT IS USED

List all assumptions, plot each on the critical × uncertain grid, and design cheap tests for those in the high-critical, high-uncertain corner first.

WHEN IT IS USED

Before prototyping and testing, and when planning implementation risk.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Product teams, founders and innovation managers.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO PRIOR PRACTICE

It brings **risk triage** to design thinking, ensuring the first tests attack the assumptions most likely to kill the idea.

FIGURE 1 · ASSUMPTION MAP

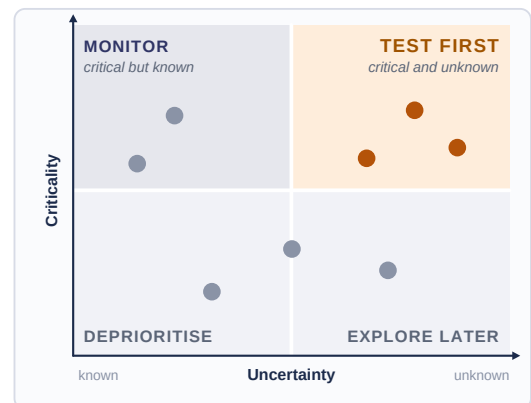


Figure 1. Assumptions plotted by criticality and uncertainty; the top-right quadrant is tested first.

RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Minimum Viable Product (MVP) *Slibrary 8*

Define Success *Slibrary 10*

Context Mapping *Slibrary 6*

SOURCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Lewrick, M., Link, P. and Leifer, L. (2020) *The Design Thinking Toolbox*. Hoboken, NJ: Wiley.

Bland, D.J. and Osterwalder, A. (2019) *Testing Business Ideas*. Hoboken, NJ: Wiley.